WHITETAIL SYNDICATE / 03 OCTOBER 2026

Site audit.
Local build review.

The storefront needs a repair pass before a launch push. Customers can buy, but the current presentation makes promises the site does not fulfill: a story link opens sign-in, video buttons do nothing, and Rutline looks like an empty store instead of a planned scent launch.

Current scope	Verified result
113 product records	Full catalog metadata inventory; 25 repeated-title groups contain 61 listings. These are review candidates, not confirmed duplicates.
7 shopping collections + Rutline	Collection structure and visible samples reviewed; men's items appear in Doe, and the $90 duffle appears in Fawn and Yearling.
Purchase baseline	One beanie, size M, carried correctly to cart and checkout. Test item removed; no order placed.
Local revision	New brand sections and theme source built. Nothing uploaded, saved or published in Shopify.
Test status	Theme Check: zero errors and no new warnings. Browser verification of this revision is pending.

What is ready

The exact supplied primary mark; readable collection links without false lifestyle mockups; factual draft Our Story copy; a Rut Line scents coming-soon state; plain collection headers; square product-card media; one general newsletter; and removal of generic social-site links.

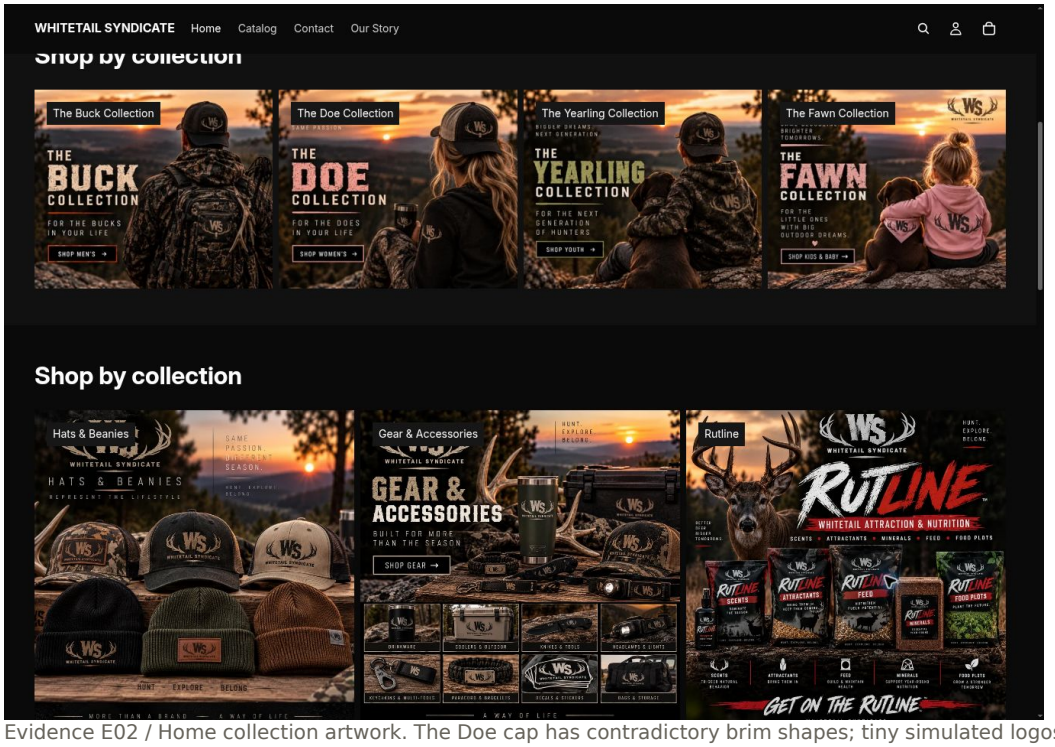
What this is not claiming

This is a local revision for review, not a finished storefront launch. All 113 product records were inventoried, but every product image, size combination and product detail page was not individually inspected. No paid orders, email signups or contact submissions were made. Shipping rates, tax, payment capture and POD fulfillment have not been tested.

Evidence is from the current storefront and a read-only view of the hidden Our Story page. Product and collection data remain unchanged. The original recovered theme was preserved byte-for-byte.

01 / VISUAL & CONTENT FAILURES

The first impression breaks trust

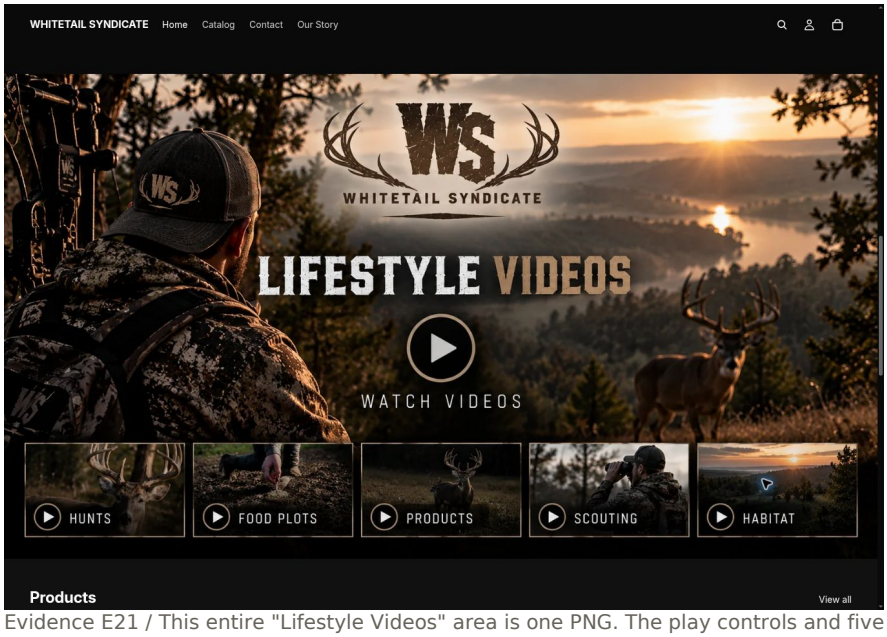


Evidence E02 / Home collection artwork. The Doe cap has contradictory brim shapes; tiny simulated logos and shop labels vary across the scene. Gear/Rutline panels portray a broader assortment than the verified launch scope.

ID / priority	Observed problem	Local correction / remaining work
F01 / High	Malformed lifestyle mockups; tiny baked-in shop labels and inconsistent simulated artwork.	Home cards replaced by native text links. Product mockups and supplier print files still require SKU-level review.
F02 / High	Rutline artwork advertises scents, feed, minerals, attractants and food plots although the current plan is scents coming soon.	Remove that panel from the home revision. New scent-only status and copy; no fabricated packaging or performance claims.
F03 / High	Main hero is cropped at 365px and the meaningful logo image has an empty alt attribute.	Supplied primary mark displayed with contain sizing, explicit dimensions and descriptive alt text. Browser reflow check pending.
F04 / Medium	Collection headers place headings over a cropped logo/deer scene.	Replace with plain readable native headings.
F05 / Medium	Two repeated collection headings, generic "Welcome to our store", and supplier-style product titles weaken hierarchy.	Native grouped shop navigation and brand announcement added. Product titles need separate data edits.

02 / FALSE DESTINATIONS

A visitor expects a story or a video



Evidence E21 / This entire "Lifestyle Videos" area is one PNG. The play controls and five video-category tiles are pictures, not video controls.

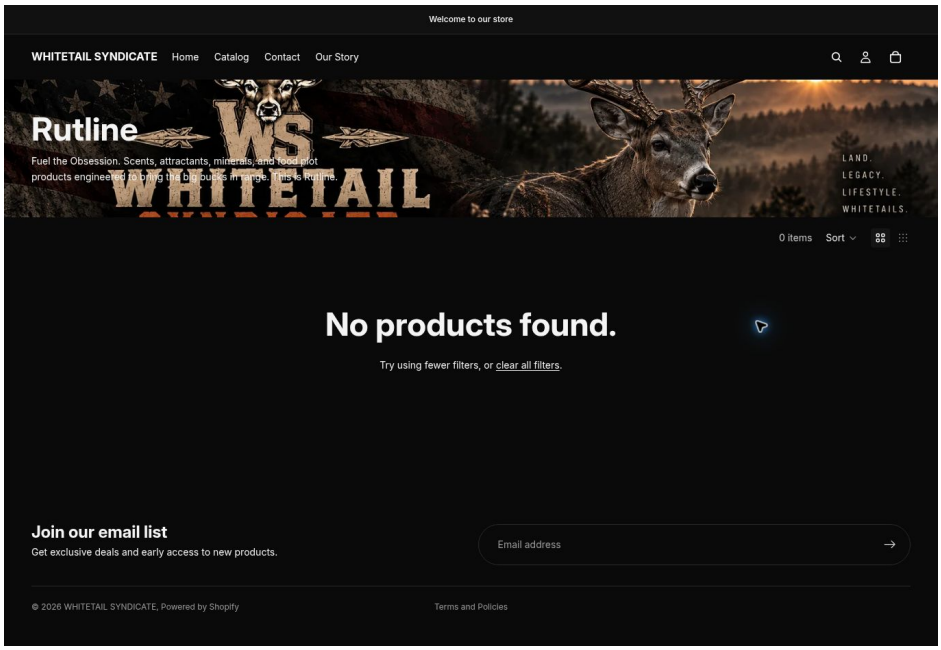
ID / priority	Observed problem	Correction / gate
F06 / High	Our Story navigation opens the customer account sign-in flow.	New theme-owned navigation reaches the homepage story. Shared Shopify menu has not been changed.
F07 / High	Actual Our Story page exists but is Hidden with empty content.	Separate our-story template supplied. Page visibility, final copy and template assignment remain future data changes.
F08 / High	No actual video or video iframe exists in the main homepage content; the picture offers several false play targets.	Picture removed from the home revision. Replace with hunter-story copy and a real contact CTA. Add a player only after real video and permissions exist.
F09 / Medium	Source social settings contain generic Facebook / Instagram / YouTube / TikTok / X root URLs.	Clear those defaults in local source. Add only verified brand profile URLs.
F10 / Medium	Contact page is a bare form without an order-help route, response process or hunt-story intake guidance.	Existing contact page retained. Define the inbox owner, story questions, permissions and response process before promotion.

Draft Our Story direction

Whitetail Syndicate brings together apparel and the people behind the hunt. We are gathering real accounts of the preparation, long sits, missed chances and moments that stay with a hunter. The copy describes work under way; it does not invent an origin story, testimonials or a finished documentary library.

03 / THE RUT LINE

Coming soon should feel intentional



Evidence E03 / Current /collections/rutline shows 0 items and "No products found" with an irrelevant clear-filters suggestion.

ID / priority	Observed problem	Local behavior
F11 / High	Empty shopping page reads as a failed search or missing inventory.	"Rut Line scents" / "Coming soon" / brief launch status. Suppress the product grid, filters, count and empty-shop message for this handle.
F12 / High	Copy says products are engineered to bring bucks in range; that capability is unverified.	No performance, ingredient, scent-type or launch-date claims in the draft.
F13 / Medium	No explicit intent capture for the planned scent launch.	Native customer interest form in source with newsletter and rut-line-interest tags, required email, translated errors and success state. Local preview never sends data.

Review before use

Approve the product status and email wording. Define who owns the interest list, what updates will be sent, and how subscribers can unsubscribe. The form has not been submitted or connected to a new automation. Rut apparel already in the catalog remains separate from this scent-launch state.

The scent page follows the confirmed scope: scents coming soon. It does not rename all Rut apparel or introduce feed/minerals/food-plot branches.

04 / CATALOG & PURCHASE CLARITY

The catalog needs a controlled migration

ID / priority	Verified problem	Work required
F14 / High	113 products; 25 repeated-title groups covering 61 records. Same titles can have different art, suppliers, costs or prices.	Map blank/garment, design, size, color, supplier, SKU, variant image and fulfillment linkage before deciding what becomes a variant.
F15 / High	Doe includes Men's Rash Guard / Men's windbreaker; Fawn and Yearling include a $90 duffle.	Repair manual membership or collection rules after establishing the target taxonomy. Theme source cannot change this data.
F16 / High	POD purchase information is incomplete near the tested beanie: delivery/production expectations, returns/exchanges and a usable size guide are absent.	Confirm supplier-specific facts and merchant policy decisions; show concise details near purchase controls.
F17 / Medium	Supplier-style names include All-Over Print / With Box / 230GSM; some image alt text exposes product codes or "Product mockup".	Approve a brand naming convention, meaningful image descriptions, and SKU-level copy.
F18 / Medium	Unequal card image ratios leave jagged product rows.	Square gallery settings added to home and collection templates. Check for logo/detail crop in actual product cards before using.
F19 / Medium	Home featured collection defaults to the broad all-products assortment; repeated beanie titles compete without design names.	Choose a reviewed launch collection and distinguish designs. Current all-products binding is retained until that collection exists.
F20 / High	Public footer / checkout surface only Privacy policy; requested shipping, refund and terms search returned no content.	Draft accurate policies from confirmed fulfillment and business decisions, then add prominent links. No invented return terms.
F21 / Low	Two general newsletter areas and generic offers duplicate the same action.	Remove extra home signup; retain one footer signup with brand-specific copy. Rut interest form is a distinct purpose.
F22 / Investigate	Beanie recommendations remained in loading state during the sampled journey.	Reproduce on an actual device and inspect Shopify recommendations. Captured console errors were browser-extension errors, not proof of a storefront cause.

All observed prices are current catalog data, not recommended launch prices. Cost, shipping, fees, promotions and margin need a supplier-based price worksheet before repricing.

05 / REPEATED-TITLE REGISTER

25 groups to investigate, not blindly merge

Current title	Listings	Observed base prices / supplier
Youth t-shirt	2	$19.00-$24.00 / WHITETAIL SYNDICATE
Women's relaxed v-neck t-shirt	3	$28.00-$29.00 / WHITETAIL SYNDICATE
DryBlend® T-Shirt	2	$30.00 / WHITETAIL SYNDICATE
Kiss-cut vinyl decals	2	$7.50-$12.00 / WHITETAIL SYNDICATE
Windshield Sunshade | 137cm(53.9")	2	$37.50 / Yoycol
Womens Lightweight Wash Sweatshirt	2	$49.00 / Apliiq
All-Over Print Men's Hoodie With Double-side Print Hood	2	$49.00 / Yoycol
All-Over Print Men's Stand-up Collar Vest	2	$49.00 / Yoycol
Womens Lightweight Wash Hooded Sweatshirt	3	$52.86 / Apliiq
Men's windbreaker	2	$59.00 / WHITETAIL SYNDICATE
All-Over Print Beanie	2	$29.00-$30.00 / WHITETAIL SYNDICATE
Toddler fleece pullover hoodie	2	$34.00 / WHITETAIL SYNDICATE
Kids crew neck sweatshirt	2	$26.00-$30.00 / WHITETAIL SYNDICATE
Baby short sleeve one piece	3	$30.00-$32.00 / WHITETAIL SYNDICATE
Value Fleece Vest	3	$48.00 / Apliiq
skull cap	5	$26.96-$29.00 / Apliiq
Vintage Cotton Twill Cap	2	$27.00 / WHITETAIL SYNDICATE
Lightweight Crop Hoodie	4	$49.00 / Apliiq
Women's garment dye cropped tee	2	$29.00-$30.00 / WHITETAIL SYNDICATE
Women's micro rib racer tank top	2	$35.00 / WHITETAIL SYNDICATE
Camouflage trucker hat	3	$29.00-$30.00 / WHITETAIL SYNDICATE
Posi UV Pro Hoodie	2	$68.34 / Apliiq
Avenue Pullover Hooded Sweatshirt	2	$63.06-$65.00 / Apliiq
Tapered stainless steel tumbler	2	$34.00 / WHITETAIL SYNDICATE
Cotton Blend Cap	3	$34.84 / Apliiq

Full product IDs, handles, variants, options, vendors and observed prices are included in catalog-current.json. Different artwork and garments may appropriately remain separate products even when current titles match.

06 / AUDIT WALKTHROUGH

What was observed, and its current health

Step	Surface	Health	Evidence / result
01	Homepage desktop	Needs repair	Native hero / announcement / category hierarchy; E01-E02.
02	Homepage 365px preview	Needs repair	Logo cropped and baked-in category copy hard to read; E26.
03	Collection imagery	Needs repair	Contradictory cap shapes, simulated logos and false assortment imagery; E02.
04	Rutline destination	Broken intent	Empty shop instead of scent-launch status; E03.
05	Our Story menu	Wrong destination	Opens customer sign-in; E04.
06	Actual Our Story page	Unavailable	Hidden and blank, observed read-only; E24.
07	Contact page	Incomplete	Form visible; response / story intake workflow undefined. No submission.
08	Buck collection / 44	Needs cleanup	Repeated skull caps / supplier names; E06 and collection text.
09	Doe collection / 33	Needs cleanup	Men's items and repeated titles; E07 and collection text.
10	Yearling collection / 10	Needs cleanup	Duffle / beanies / baby items mixed with youth; collection text.
11	Fawn collection / 7	Needs cleanup	Duffle and kids / baby assortment mixed; E09.
12	Hats 25 / Gear 16	Needs cleanup	Repeated design/product names; Gear source sample E11.
13	All-products inventory	Needs cleanup	All 113 records captured, 25 repeated-title groups.
14	Sample product / size	Works; info gaps	S changed to M. Missing clear fit / delivery / returns guidance; E13-E14.
15	Cart / checkout entry	Baseline pass	M and $30 carried through; E17-E19. No address or order submitted.
16	Lifestyle video block	False controls	One PNG, no player or main-content video links; E21.
17	Footer / policies	Incomplete	Privacy only visible, generic social roots, duplicate signup.
18	Local theme source	Review ready	No new Theme Check diagnostics. Browser runtime acceptance pending.

The audit spans visual presentation, navigation, catalog structure, content/trust, and the commerce/source boundary. It is not a claim that every product and page was visited five times. No accessibility-conformance or speed certification is claimed.

07 / TESTING & NEXT SEQUENCE

Review first. Then work in measured stages.

Check	Result	Limit
Shopify Theme Check 3.30.1	PASS: 0 errors / 0 new warnings	Six original warnings remain in existing header/divider files.
JSON / JSONC / Liquid schemas	PASS	All 76 JSON-family files and 140 embedded schemas parsed.
JavaScript syntax	PASS	81 existing JS files and local preview script parsed. Source theme adds no new commerce JS.
Asset fidelity / backup / ZIP	PASS	Three supplied assets copied exactly. Original source matched its backup. Theme ZIP CRC verified.
New Liquid brand sections	PASS: local rendering	Home / scents / story markup rendered from source with merchant defaults. Local substitute form is inert.
Actual revised-page browser behavior	PENDING	Cloud browser blocks local file URLs. Local HTML is supplied for user review; Shopify rendering requires later explicit direction.
Checkout / fulfillment / delivery	PENDING for revision	Baseline cart entry passed. No rate, tax, payment, provider mapping or fulfillment test completed.

1. Review the local revision / Craig

Open the single-file preview. Review Home, Rut Line scents and Our Story at desktop and 365px. Confirm the exact primary mark, wording, navigation and story contact path. The preview demonstrates brand sections; it does not replace a Shopify runtime test.

2. Lock artwork and a launch assortment / Craig + owner

Finish the five approved design masters with repeatable WS and antlers, no W&S, named files and revision control. Select a small reviewed launch collection. Audit every selected SKU against real supplier mockups and samples.

3. Prepare catalog and policy changes / store admin + POD owner

Use the 113-record register to plan merges, variant mappings, redirects and collection repairs. Confirm production estimates, delivery regions, support ownership, returns and size charts. Establish price/margin decisions from actual costs.

4. Run a real draft-store test after explicit authorization

Import an unpublished copy only when directed. Assign approved page templates and resource changes, then check desktop/mobile reflow, keyboard links, valid/invalid email behavior, product images, variant choice, cart changes, checkout shipping and provider routing. Order tests require a defined item and budget.

5. Publish and promote after the acceptance gate

Publication waits for separate direction. Keep the live theme rollback, verify production routes after launch, then connect real story videos, approved profiles and campaign tracking. Keep scent interest separate from apparel shopping.

Official platform workflow references are in README_LOCAL_REVIEW.md. Findings in this report are direct observations.